books, so I thought, 'this will be easy'," says Rockwell. "Of course, it wasn't. The things that are happening in this scene are so surreal that it's difficult to pin them down exactly. But I was able to quote my own earlier translations of *Tamas* and *Gujarat Pakistan Se Gujarat Hindustan* and that felt good because Partition literature has been a recurring theme in my translations, and I have written scholarly works about it as well."

Rockwell is also a painter and a writer herself. These two other vocations converge in her 2012 book *The Little Book of Terror*, which combines her striking artwork with non-fiction writings that critique (among other things), the West's myopic 'global war on terror'. Her paternal grandfather was the iconic American illustrator and artist Norman Rockwell (1894-1978), whose works are considered to be a kind of artistic record of the country's history from the 1930s to the 1970s. As Daisy recalls during the interview, Norman loved to work "with narrative inside his head"; his wife had read the entirety of *War and Peace* aloud to him twice while he worked.

"The reason I'm bringing this up," she says, "is that there is a lot of flow between the written medium and artwork, which is very interesting to me. Sometimes, when I'm illustrating or making a portrait, the work is similar to translation in that I'm initially trying to represent something accurately, but you have to leave that behind at some point and let the work become a creative thing that stands on its own." ■

–Aditya Mani Jha

BOOKS

OUT OF A NIGHTMARE

None of **Anjana Menon's** breezy observations quite captures the horror of our ongoing pandemic





ONAM IN A NIGHTIE
Stories from a Kerala Quarantine
by Anjana Menon
HARPERCOLLINS INDIA
₹299; 260 pages



Outbreaks and epidemics may make for great literature, but the pandemic seems to have shaken the ground a writer stands on. Till it ends, or even flags, how can we write authentically or rationally about it? Unless engaged in the essential work of documenting the economic, social and psychological impact of the virus on the world, the thoughtful writer seems to have been silenced.

In the early weeks and months, there were no doubt many who considered that their personal "pandemic journey" (stuck in a house with as many bathrooms as inmates and enough provisions for a year) might entertain readers. But as the death toll galloped toward a million and then leaped into the stratosphere, it seemed appropriate to stop sharing recipes on Facebook and posting updates on one's domestic predicaments. Those of us who forgot what that shift felt like may want to Google "terrible video of celebrities singing 'Imagine'".

Still, the voice of privilege soldiers on, in chicklit and richlit everywhere. Anjana Menon's *Onam in a Nightie* is a non-fictional account of the return of a television journalist to her parents' home in Kerala. Having never really lived in Kerala, she spins her discoveries of mosquitoes and the "bizarre barter system" of fruit pickers into far more chapters than we expect. The flimsiest anecdotes are padded with explanations of snakeboat races, elephants and Onam feasts, as well as the kind of glib commentaries on Kerala's health system, demographics, unions and shopping malls that appear endlessly in weekend supplements. We are even told who Indira Gandhi was.

ANJANA MENON'S experiences might have been better consumed as a longish essay

Menon's own experiences might have been tolerable in a longish essay, but when stretched out to book length, they are mind-numbing. Occasionally, her writing rises from annoying to offensive, as when she mentions the air pollution caused by "iron-lunged" Punjabi and Haryani farmers, so distressing to the well-heeled of Delhi, who merrily escalate their own consumption.

Near the end, there is a clutter of footnotes, glossary and index incongruous with the tone of the book. Flitting through this entire misguided endeavour are the pure, evocative drawings of the teenage Anujath Sindhu Vinaylal, an artist with an eye beyond his tender years. Now, there's a story we may want to hear. ■

–Latha Anantharaman